

opment scheme, we have adopted 145 remote villages from backward or aspirational districts across 24 States since 2017, and strategically implemented interventions targeting the main problem areas in the rural ecosystem - education, healthcare, water and sanitation, livelihood generation, digitalization and infrastructural development, among other things. In 6 years, we have learnt how to build effective, durable programs which keep bearing fruit long after, by involving the community from the planning to the execution stage, and strengthening the community to assume the reins upon the end of the nodal agency's engagement. Here are some of our learnings:

Following a bottom-up approach from the starting line

Our program adopts a bottom-up approach by forefronting the communities' perspectives in the design of the interventions. This is achieved by building teams with immersive field experience and not surface-level engagements, holding regular interactions with the communities, poring over analytical and suggestive policy papers, followed by last mile delivery. This is how Gram Seva has evolved into a community-led movement. Through exercises like Participatory Rural Appraisal, the initiatives for each location were decided by the communities themselves.

For instance, the women of Kelur village in Gadag District, Karnataka proposed to carry out goat-rearing as an alternate source of livelihood. Once they were trained in goat-rearing and after our seed investment, we jointly conceptualised a model with the community wherein the goats bred in every reproductive cycle would be handed over to a new set of beneficiaries. While our involvement with this intervention ended in 2021, the women have continued to diligently transfer the kid goats to the next set of women, thereby creating a unique chain or loop of natural continuity of benefit transfer.

Demonstrating the value and encouraging the community to share the load

We collect nominal monetary contributions from the community to build stakes and foster a sense of ownership for the assets created, so as to iron out any potential issues surrounding repair and maintenance. While the usual norm is to collect 10-20 percent of the cost from the community, for interventions that pique the community's interest, we have had instances where the community has even augmented our corpus with an equal contribution. In Gavandhara Village, Beed district, Maharashtra, we established an RO unit with our partner NGO, Dilasa Sanstha, with the dual purpose of driving access to clean drinking water for the village, as well as monetising the surplus. A



Self Help Group (SHG) was identified to assume the reins of the unit. Under the program, we provided 50 water jars, while the women procured another 50. We also liaised with the Panchayat, which integrated a chilling unit into our machinery. This SHG-driven RO plant is now catering to households in the area who don't have to travel to distant places for clean drinking water, and also receives orders for water jars during the wedding season. Nearby hotels are sourcing their water from this unit as well.

Similarly, under Gram Seva's education component, an educated, enthusiastic person from the village is identified, paid an honorarium and guided to build a vibrant space and conducive learning environment for conducting tuitions. Transforming the Gram Seva Kendra, our community information centres, into a colourful stimulating learning space, the cadres encourage the children to come, study, and try to incorporate overall physical and mental development activities with team-building games, Rubik's cubes, puzzles and co-curricular activities such as painting, singing, dancing, puppet-shows etc. The parents from Deopur village in Siddharthnagar District, Uttar Pradesh understood the benefits of their children attending these co-curricular classes. When our engagement ended, they decided to foot the teacher's fees themselves. When they were facing financial issues, some willingly paid the teacher in kind, by way of a few kilos of rice or wheat from their farms.

Seeking 'Shram Daan' or labour contribution

In another remote village from Mamit District in Mizoram named Bawngva, under Gram Seva's Rural Infrastructure

component, the villagers came forward to build a "People's Pavement". The construction of this road, connecting the village to the Gram Seva Kendra, was anchored by the youth who took charge and structured how much labour the whole community would contribute systematically. With more skin in the game in the form of the labour invested, the assets created are much more likely to be utilised optimally and maintained.

Strengthening village institutions

After assets are created, we transfer the ownership to the Village Development Committee or Gram Seva Committees which are constituted under the program. We focus on capacity building of the Committee for undertaking long-term repair and maintenance of the assets we create, thus eliminating the need for external support in the future.

As the country embarks upon the journey to become a developed nation by 2047, the SBI Gram Seva model sets a precedent of how community participation and collective efforts can lead to rural growth, thus realizing Mahatma Gandhi's dream of Gram Swaraj. The CSR sector is evolving to not just fulfil a mandate for statutory compliance, but make meaningful contributions to nation building. Borrowing the wisdom of legacy NGOs and investing in engaging more closely with remote marginalised communities, CSRs must make consistent and concerted efforts to bridge these knowledge gaps, cut through gender, caste and class disparities, to involve the most important stakeholder in the development process - the community - to engineer inclusive and effective programs.

